

government employment in public services like transport, education, health, and sanitation is,” he says. Sood adds that with employment in urban centres remaining an unsolved problem for years, there is a need for sustained public investment in agriculture to absorb the workforce in a meaningful way.

Vinay K. Srivastava, Associate Professor at ITS Ghaziabad, says the agenda is quite clear from the Second Advance Estimates. “The data shows that private consumption is yet to pick up, and this is an area where the government needs to focus. It also

THERE ARE WORRIES THAT THE GOVERNMENT’S CAPITAL EXPENDITURE PLAN MAY BE IN THE SLOW LANE IN THE NEXT FEW MONTHS

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has to work on further investments in infrastructure. While capex has been high for infrastructure, the need now is to improve the quality of this expenditure and cut down on cost and time overruns. There is also need to focus on investments in energy and the environment,” he says. Employment also remains a challenge, and this has to be a priority as it can in turn boost private consumption, he notes.

The full details of the 100-day agenda fleshed out by the PM with his ministerial council are still awaited. Greater clarity on the government’s priorities for the next five years will perhaps emerge when the full Budget for 2024-25 is presented in July. **BT**

@surabhi_prasad

Q & A

“CHIPS NOT RISKY BUSINESS ANYMORE”

Union Minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar opens up on how India is pushing ahead with its semiconductor policy

BY NIDHI SINGAL

INDIA’S DECADES-OLD *dream of becoming a semiconductor nation is becoming a reality as the government has approved one fab and two more testing and packaging proposals. In conversation with Business Today, Rajeev Chandrasekhar, Minister of State for Electronics & Information Technology, talks about what this development means for India and the strategy ahead. Edited excerpts:*

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India’s dream of becoming a semiconductor nation is finally becoming a reality with the approval of the first commercial fab. What does this mean?

What we have achieved in the last two years, two months, is certainly by any stretch of imagination tremendous. Talking about pure semiconductors, we have almost \$26-27 billion of interest in terms of investment. And the companies that have lined up today are like the who’s who. In the fab

space, [there’s] Tower and PSMC; in the packaging space we have Renesas, Micron, and we have a whole set of other proposals still in the pipeline. In global R&D, you have LAM Research, Applied Materials, ASML, AMD. The entire semiconductor ecosystem is present in India with the R&D centres. We have almost 12,000 engineers who have joined VLSI degree programmes for the new curriculum this year.

Hopefully in the next few days, we will be announcing the Bharat Semiconductor Research Center, which will be co-located with the Semiconductor Laboratory. We have in the pipeline the modernisation of Semiconductor Laboratory as well for which we have seven proposals. If you look at all this, we are in an extremely good spot in terms of where we want to be in the next decade. I’m absolutely confident that if we sit down, talk in 2034, we would have significantly moved ahead of